



### Call to arms

During the Spanish Civil War, recruiting posters were an important means of communication as many people were illiterate. The Nationalist poster (c. 1936) on the left and Anti-Fascist forces poster on the right are designed to carry a clear message without needing to be read.

(a Spanish fascist party). The fascist Italian and German governments also became involved, supplying troops and weapons, which gave the civil war a dramatic international character.

On July 19, 1936, General Franco (see below), a leader of the insurgent forces, assumed command of the Army of Africa based in Morocco and took it to Spain. This army played a key part in gaining Nationalist control of southwestern Spain. At the outbreak of the war, the Republican Army was about one-third larger than the Nationalist Army. However, by the time the Army of Africa arrived in Spain, the figures were close to equal.

### International Brigades

Socialists and communists from all over Europe formed groups of volunteers called International Brigades and went

to Spain to protect the Popular Front government. Their ranks included anyone who was opposed to fascism, and Spain became the *cause célèbre* for left-leaning intellectuals across the Western world. The British government, which proclaimed itself neutral, warned that Britons who enlisted on either side

would be liable to two years in prison, and urged other states to prevent the dispatch of volunteers. Despite this deterrent, thousands of foreign idealists made their way to Spain, many of them to defend the capital city, Madrid.

### Battle for Madrid

At the outbreak of war, Madrid was controlled by the Popular Front government. Franco was anxious to capture the capital, and bombing raids began on August 28, 1936. On September 30, he captured Toledo, which is only 40 miles (65 km) from Madrid. Toledo had been in Republican hands since the beginning, despite the onslaught from thousands of Nationalist soldiers. Its capture was a huge morale boost

for the Nationalists and did much to enhance Franco's reputation. By November 1, 25,000 Nationalist troops under General José Varela had reached the western and southern suburbs of Madrid. Five days later, Varela's men were joined by the German Legion Kondor (a unit from the *Luftwaffe*, see p.392) and the siege of Madrid began. It was to last for nearly three years.

### Fascist victory

In December 1936, Benito Mussolini (see p.387), Italy's fascist ruler, began to supply the Nationalists with men and equipment. After failing to take Madrid in a full frontal assault in 1937, Franco's forces launched a campaign to conquer the Basque Provinces, Asturias, and the industrial areas of northern Spain. During this offensive, the first large-scale aerial bombing of civilians took place, including the infamous German raid that destroyed



### Guernica

Spanish artist Pablo Picasso painted this mural for the Spanish pavilion at the Paris World's Fair (an exhibition). It expresses his feelings about the destruction of the Basque town of Guernica by German air raids in 1937.

the Basque town of Guernica, an event foreshadowing episodes that occurred in World War II.

Franco was under pressure from both Hitler (see pp.390–91) and Mussolini to obtain a quick victory by taking

Madrid, so he blocked the road that linked the city to the rest of Republican Spain, and his troops attacked Guadalajara, 40 miles (65 km) east of the capital, on March 8, 1937. The Republican Army counterattacked, making use of Soviet tanks, and many lives were lost.

### Infighting

Meanwhile, there was serious infighting among Republicans in Barcelona. On May 6, 1937, death squads assassinated

a number of prominent anarchists, and rioting followed. These events severely damaged the Popular Front and led to the formation of a new government under the leadership of Juan Negrin. Negrin was a Communist sympathizer, and this enabled Joseph Stalin (see pp.378–79) to influence the Spanish government.

In April 1938, the Nationalist Army broke through the Republican defenses in the north, and Franco moved his troops toward Valencia with the aim of encircling Madrid. Negrin, eager to show that the Republican government was still viable, insisted on a policy of attack, rather than defense. However,

at the Battle of Ebro (July 25–November 16, 1938), the Republicans were all but destroyed as an effective fighting force. On January 26, 1939,

Barcelona fell to the Nationalist Army. It was a stunning victory. With further victories in Catalonia, Vinaroz, and other towns along the eastern coast,



### Nazi medal

The Spanish Cross, or Legion Kondor Cross, was a campaign medal instituted on April 14, 1939 to recognize those Germans who served in the Spanish Civil War on the side of General Franco.

### SPANISH DICTATOR (1892–1975)

#### FRANCISCO FRANCO

Franco was born into a military family. He joined the army and served in Morocco from 1910 to 1927. In 1926 he became the youngest general in Spain, and by 1936 he was chief of staff for the military. After leading the Nationalist movement to victory in the Spanish Civil War, Franco dominated Spanish politics and was the formal head of state. He wore the uniform of a captain general, a rank traditionally reserved for the king. Within three years of his death in 1975, Spain became a fully constitutional monarchy.



## AFTER

**After the Spanish Civil War, Franco took control as the country's dictator.**

### FOREIGN WITHDRAWAL

A committee in London drew up a plan to enable those who had fought in the **International Brigades** to return home. After months of negotiation, the other European powers finally gave their approval to the plan.



INTERNATIONAL BRIGADE STAMP

### FRANCO IN POWER

The methods Franco used to restore order included censorship, banning strikes, and ensuring that the Nationalists formed the only legal political party. His **enemies were sent to prison camps**, where many thousands died.

### SPAIN AND WORLD WAR II

Despite Hitler's efforts, Spain remained neutral in **World War II 392–405**, though Franco sent Germany supplies of scarce raw materials. He was penalized for this by the Allies, and Spain was barred from the **United Nations 397**.

**59 THOUSAND** foreign volunteers joined in the fight  
**500 THOUSAND** people lost their lives during the conflict  
**25 THOUSAND** people died from malnutrition